Alvin Ho: Allergic to Girls . . .

By Lenore Look

ALVIN: *(enters rooms shyly . . . already in character) (almost whispering at the beginning but gradually growing louder after his list of fears)* The first thing you should know about me is that my name is Alvin Ho. I am afraid of many things. Elevators. Tunnels. Bridges. Airplanes. Thunder. Substitute teachers. Kimchi. Wasabi. The dark. Heights. Scary movies. Scary dreams. Shots. School. If there were no school, my troubles would blast away, just like that. I would dig holes all day. I would watch cooking shows. I would keep an eye on things. It would be fantastic!

INTRODUCTION

Alvin Ho: Allergic to Girls, Schools and Other Scary Things by Lenore Look.

ALVIN: The second thing you should know about me is that I have a dog named Lucy and a brother named Calvin and a sister named Anibelly, who messes with my sticks and toys; eats my food, drinks my chocolate milk and gets in my way. I am not as big as Calvin, but I am bigger than Anibelly, who isn't a baby anymore but doesn't go to school yet. I am sort of nearly almost medium . . . when I stand on tiptoe and stretch at the same time, I am finally almost visible in my class picture!

The third thing you should know about me is that I love Plastic Man, Wonder Woman, the Green Lantern, Concrete Man, Aquaman, King Henry V and all the superheroes in the world. I know them from reading with my dad every night while my mom runs on the treadmill like a hamster on a wheel. My dad is a great reader for his age, which could be fifty or one hundred, it's hard to tell. He wears reading glasses and always puts one arm around me and his other arm

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around Anibelly and Calvin for support, on account of when you get to be that old, it is hard to do anything by yourself

The fourth thing you should know about me is that once upon a time, before I went to school, I was a superhero. I was Firecracker Man! I ran around our house, full speed ahead, screaming at the top of my lungs while beating on a garbage can lid. I was as noisy as a firecracker on Chinese New Year! But now I am Firecracker Man only on weekends and holidays. There's just no time for it. Being a superhero is hard work. You have to save the world. But going to school is even harder. You have to save yourself. Most days I can hardly even make it to the school bus. And when I arrive at school, I can't think. I can't read. I can't smile. I can't sing. I can't scream. I can't even talk.

The fifth thing you should know about me is that I have never spoken a word in school. Even when I try with all my might, I always manage to say nothing at all. My voice works at home. It works in the car. It even works on the school bus. But as soon as I get to school I am as silent as a side of beef. It is true. No one really knows why I lose my voice at school, since I come from a long line of farmer-warriors who haven't had a scaredy bone in their bodies since 714 AD. In China my ancient grandpas and grandmas and aunts and uncles fought off leopards and tigers in their gardens the way Calvin and Anibelly and I fight off mosquitoes at Walden Pond. They weren't afraid of anything. I am afraid of everything.

DAD: When I was your age . . . I was scared of school too. Worse, I was never a superhero before I went to school, so it was very rough.

ALVIN: My dad is not superhero material, but he has read practically everything ever written about superheroes and so knows us from beginning to end, which explains a lot about him.

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DAD: Just hold your head high and be a gentleman.

ALVIN: But I feel sick. *(to audience)* My dad put a hand on my forehead.

DAD: No fever.

ALIVN: Are you sure? *(to audience)* I looked at his hands. They are thick like baseball mitts. It was a wonder he could feel anything through them.

DAD: Where does it hurt?

ALVIN: All over. *(to audience)* It was true; I was not making it up. I gave a little moan. *(moans pitifully)*

DAD: Hmmmmm *(Alvin moans again even more pitifully)* You are not sick.

ALVIN: But I will be. I will be very, very sick. I'm allergic to school, *severely* allergic."

DAD: Alvin. *(coming down to Alvin's level and putting one of his mitts on Alvin's shoulder)* You will be okay, son.

ALVIN: I love it when he calls me that. Son. I felt a little better. Maybe my dad was right, maybe I would be okay. A good word from my dad changes everything. Besides, if I missed the bus, my dad might have a few other words for me. So I dashed out of the house and caught up with Calvin just as the bus was pulling up to the end of our driveway. We waved and climbed on. I was okay. "You will be okay, son," my dad's voice echoed between my ears. I smiled at Calvin. And Calvin smiled back. I was okay.

Then we arrived at school. My sneakers landed like a couple of cement blocks when I got off the bus. *Pfuump, pfuump.* My stomach turned like a washing machine when I got inside. I found the door that said "Second Grade, Miss Pestalozzi." My throat tightened.

MISS P: Welcome. I'm Miss P.

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ALVIN: I stopped dead in my tracks. Her hair was shiny and her skin was clean. She smelled like fresh laundry out of the dryer. She smiled at me. But I did not smile back. I hardly even looked at her. I felt dizzy. Everything whirled around me. I was in the middle of it, but I was not in it at all. So far, second grade wasn't any different from first grade, which wasn't any different from kindergarten. I was thinking about running and hiding, when ...

FLEA: Wanna be desk buddies again?

ALVIN: It was Flea. She was my desk buddy in first grade. She is a girl. I wanted to say no way. Nobody wants a girl desk buddy, except for maybe a girl. The scary thing about girls is that they are not boys. They can't punch. But they can kick, which hurts. They skip rope too fast. They are boring. I opened my mouth to tell her all this, but . . . My tongue turned into sandpaper. Nothing came out.

FLEA: C'mon. You can sit with me and Esha.

ALVIN: Everyone was choosing their seat and sitting down. Soon it would be too late to sit with the boys. I opened my mouth. I wished for my voice. I wished and wished and wished. But nothing came out. Finally, I slumped into the chair. I was not okay. I was so allergic to school, but I was even more allergic to girls!

TRANSITION

So Alvin began to concoct a plan . . . Obviously moaning and claiming to be sick didn't work. His dad was too smart to fall for just pretending to be sick. The best way to avoid school, as everyone knows is to really, truly get sick!!

ALVIN: But not all sicknesses are created equal. Some are better than others. Tonsillitis, for example, is pretty good. You get all the Italian ice you want. It is my dream to have tonsillitis someday. Appendicitis is good too, but not as good as a *burst* appendix, which gets you a ride in a wailing ambulance speeding

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through all the red lights on Route 62 to Emerson Hospital. This happened when Calvin's appendix burst and our mom found him on the kitchen floor. He has all the luck!

The flu is okay, but it's not great. You only get ginger ale and crackers, which is a real rip-off, but usually you get to watch all the cooking shows and cartoons you want. The common cold? One bad-tasting zinc drop, some tissues and you're back in school the next day.

Medical mysteries? If you get foreign-accent syndrome or barking madness or squeaky chalk phobia, forget it. You're back in school the *same* day. So you have to be patient. It's like choosing a car, or a house; my mom says you shouldn't jump at the first offer because a better deal might be right around the corner.

And it was. One day, Jules was out-with chicken pox.

MISS P: Don't go near Jules's house. It'll take two weeks for all the blisters to scab over completely. Until then, Jules 1s highly contagious.

ALVIN: Highly contagious? I felt like dancing! I nearly burst like fireworks! But I didn't. I had to wait until after school. It was hard *not* to go near Jules's house. It is on the way to everything. It is as though Jules's house is a big magnet and I am an iron filing, and every time I so much as step out of my house, I am yanked toward it, just like that. That was exactly what happened! I was sucked by such a powerful force toward Jules's house that I could barely even pick up the fat frog in the gutter on my way. And when I got to Jules's house, there was already a line behind the tall bushes in front, just like the line at the cinema when there's a scary movie playing. *(to the kids in line)* Hey, guys!

ELI: *(hiding in the bushes)* Shhhhhhhh! Stay low or Jules's mom will see us and we'll all get sent home.

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ALVIN: Before I knew it, it was my turn. I caught my frog, rushed around the side of the house and ran right into Pinky under Jules's window.

PINKY: Watch where you're going! *(holding out a coffee can)*

ALVIN: He held out a can. On the can was a label: *One-minute visit: 50¢ Jump into bed· $1*

PINKY: You got a dollar?

ALVIN: I gasped. Normally, Pinky does not speak to me. Usually I do not show up on his radar, not one bleep, not even a flicker. But I was flickering now! *(shaking his head no)*

PINKY: You got fifty cents?

ALVIN: No. *(to Pinky)* Wait! *(to audience)* I remember[ed] an unchewed piece of gum in my back pocket. I took it out. It was warm and soft. Pinky grabbed the gum, unwrapped it and stuffed it into his cheek.

PINKY: *(speaking around the wad of gum)* Okay. You get a minute.

ALVIN: I took my frog and hopped through Jules's window. Jules was in bed. *(to Jules as he look around the room and under the bed)* So where's the chicken?

JULES: I was wondering that myself. I wish I knew.

ALVIN: I was really disappointed. How do you catch chicken pox without first catching a chicken? *(To Jules)* I came to catch the *chicken* pox. Not the plain pox. *(to audience)* But the plain pox wasn't too shabby. It had turned Jules's head into a potato covered with red eyes. Some eyes were crying, others were crusty like sugar on a cookie. It was great! Jules had never looked scarier!

Jules was scratching like crazy. I do not know if Jules is a girl or a boy. Sometimes Jules plays with the boys, and other times Jules plays with the girls.

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"Jules" could stand for "Julian'' or it could stand for "Julia." It is hard to tell. The blisters didn't help either. In fact, they made Jules look like neither boy nor girl. Instead, Jules looked a good deal like an alien. A real live alien potato fresh off a UFO. *(to Jules)* You're so lucky! I'd love to look like that.

JULES: *(scratching like crazy)* Yeah, It's really great except for the itching.

ALVIN: You got any you can't reach?

JULES: *(squirming)* Yeah, right up the middle of my back.

ALVIN: So I gave Jules a hand. I think it is one of the rules of being a gentleman, but I don't really know, I can't remember.

PINKY: Time's up! *(hissing from the window)*

ALVIN: [But] None of us caught a chicken or even saw one. So none of us broke out with the chicken pox that day. Or the plain pox either. It was a terrible disappointment.

Then a long time later . . . just when we'd forgotten all about Jules and the chicken pox, and none of us were trying to catch anything anymore . . . a miracle happened. Our art teacher, Mr. Gruenert, was showing us famous self-portraits one warm afternoon. Frida Kahlo looked a little itchy to me with branches coming out of her hair. Paul Gauguin looked a bit feverish because he was in Tahiti, where it's really hot. And Vincent van Gogh, in his scratchy straw hat, *definitely* looked itchy. . . . Very itchy.

Then we got mirrors and brushes so that we could paint our own self-portraits. My self-portrait was going to be a masterpiece, but strangely . . . I didn't feel like painting. I didn't feel like doing anything at all. I felt strange.

Then I looked into the mirror. Something scary stared back. *(screaming)*

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Aaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaack! Then Flea, who was next to me, looked at me.

FLEA: *Aaaaaaaaaieeeeeeeeee!"*

ALVIN: The other girls screamed too. Some ran fast. Others ran faster. You'd think we were a bunch of aliens or something. School shut down for two weeks and a half after that. There was a story about us in the newspaper so that people as far away as Andover, Massachusetts, read about the great chicken pox epidemic in Concord. We were famous! The newspaper said ... The first victim had been carefully quarantined. All the children had been warned to keep away. How the epidemic ever got started was a complete mystery. *(Alvin smiles proudly and knowningly and raises his hands in the air in victory)*

[The sixth thing you should know about me is that my name is Alvin Ho and I caught the chicken pox!!]

SOURCE INFORMATION

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